Chapter Eighty-Seven

The Hussite Uprising

Between 1388 and 1419,
the German cities rebel against their king,
and the Bohemian Hussites rebel against their church

THE KING OF THE GERMANS had been on his throne for ten years. For nearly the entire time, he had been at war with his own people.

Wenceslaus IV, twenty-seven years old, had followed his father, the Emperor Charles IV, onto the imperial throne. Just before his death in 1378, Charles IV had guaranteed his son's election by distributing cash presents to the electors. To raise the money, Charles had mortgaged a cluster of imperial cities in Swabia; Wenceslaus inherited both the German crown and their displeasure.

"Imperial cities," or *Reichsstädte,* had been founded on royal-owned land, or had grown up around imperial castles. They were directly under the authority of the Holy Roman Emperor; imperial cities paid their taxes straight into the royal treasury, answered only to the emperor's appointed governor (and not to any duke or elector, even if they stood within his duchy), and swore allegiance to the emperor alone.[1]

To "mortgage" an imperial city was to hand it over to the control of another, in return for payment; Charles IV had sold the right to appoint